

Naulakha Pavilion

نولکھا محل

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Emperor Shah Jahan; architect Wazir Khan of Lahore, with civil engineer Abd al-Karim
- Built in: 1631-1633 CE
- Cost: Popularly said to have cost, or been decorated with gemstones worth, nine lakh rupees (900,000) - the source of its name - though the exact historical figure is not independently documented
- Built for: A small, private personal chamber for the emperor, beside the Sheesh Mahal courtyard

2. Construction Details

- Materials: White marble throughout, originally inlaid with precious and semi-precious stones
- Technique: A distinctive curvilinear roofline inspired by Bengali (do-chala) roof architecture, unusual within the otherwise Persian-Timurid vocabulary of the fort
- Craftsmen involved: Not individually documented beyond the architect (Wazir Khan) and engineer (Abd al-Karim) credited with the design
- Time taken: Roughly two years (1631-1633)

3. Historical Background

- Originally offered a panoramic view of the Ravi River, which at the time flowed close to the fort's northern wall; today the view is of the old city, since the river has since shifted course.
- Much of the original gemstone inlay described in early accounts has since been lost, though the marble structure and its distinctive roof survive.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- The pavilion directly inspired the writer Rudyard Kipling, who lived in Lahore in the 1880s; he co-wrote a novel titled *The Naulahka* and later named his own house in Vermont, USA, "Naulakha" after this very building.
- Its motif has appeared on Pakistani currency, and its design is reported to have influenced the architecture of the Pakistani Embassy in Washington, D.C.
- "Naulakha" literally means "worth nine lakhs" - accounts differ on whether this referred to the construction cost or to the value of the gemstones originally inlaid into its walls.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Imagine Shah Jahan stepping out onto this small marble balcony on a clear morning in 1633, the Ravi River glinting just beyond the fort wall, and choosing - out of an entire palace complex - this one modest room, built in a foreign roofline he liked, as his most private retreat. Two and a half centuries later, a young writer named Kipling would stand somewhere near this same spot, fall in love with the building's name, and carry it home with him to a hillside in Vermont.

AI Heritage Revive — Lahore Fort landmark reference. Compiled from encyclopedic research report; figures marked "Not documented" are intentionally left blank rather than estimated.